

At the dawn of the Indian Republic in 1950, the country had a literacy rate of 18 per cent. Today nearly 78 per cent Indians are literate. Launched in 1989, the total literacy campaign played a significant role in enabling this achievement. Born in Kerala's Ernakulam as a joint effort between the district administration and the popular science movement Kerala Sasthra Sahithya Parishad, it soon morphed into a national campaign with the creation of the Bharat Gyan Vigyan Samiti, a non-government partner in this effort. It mobilised the bureaucracy and civil society into working together and shaped many significant efforts to expand school education, enlisting 15 million volunteers and 150 million people to attend literacy classes across the country.

National Sample Survey

"Where Mahalanobis and India led, the rest of the world followed"—this is what Nobel laureate Angus Deaton and co-author Valarie Kozel wrote of India's statistical system, and specifically the National Sample Survey (NSS), in 2005. Pioneered by the father of Indian statistics P.C. Mahalanobis in 1950, the NSS soon became the envy of the globe, with the World Bank and the United Nations adopting and adapting NSS methods. The surveys offered critical evidence on the realities of everyday economic life—consumption, employment, poverty. This enabled knowledge-creation, evidence and, above all, public scrutiny, mobilisation and contestation over welfare policies. The NSS and India's statistical system, more generally, are key pillars of our democracy. Today, this remarkable global achievement is suffering a severe credibility crisis, and is in urgent need of rescue.

Pulse Polio Campaign

'*Do boond zindagi ki*'—Amitabh Bachchan's famous polio immunisation campaign of the early 2000s has become synonymous with India's greatest public health achievement. From accounting for 60 per cent of global polio cases in 1994, India was declared polio-free two decades later. It took concerted government action, from committing financial resources to empowering an army of frontline workers, involving ordinary citizens and innovative awareness drives. This is a fine example of what can be achieved when citizens and the state come together. Not to forget, it also paved the ground for India's successful Covid-19 vaccination drive.



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